

ANGEL ACTION · PRIMARY SURVEY

DRSABCD Action Plan

The DRSABCD action plan is the Australian Resuscitation Council's seven-step primary survey for any emergency: Danger, Response, Send for help, Airway, Breathing, CPR, Defibrillation.

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What DRSABCD stands for

DRSABCD (sometimes written D.R.S.A.B.C.D.) is the order of priorities you work through whenever you reach an unwell or injured person in Australia. It is taught in every accredited first aid course and underpins every other protocol in this knowledge base.

1. **D — Danger.** Check the scene is safe for you, bystanders and the patient before approaching. Common dangers include traffic, electricity, fire, water, fumes and aggressive animals or people.
2. **R — Response.** Talk and touch. Ask loudly *"Can you hear me? Open your eyes. Squeeze my hand."* Use the COWS approach (Can you hear me? Open your eyes. What's your name? Squeeze my hand).
3. **S — Send for help.** Call **000** for an ambulance. Put your phone on speaker so you can keep your hands free.
4. **A — Airway.** Open the mouth. If there is fluid or a visible obstruction, roll the person on their side and clear it. Then tilt the head back and lift the chin to open the airway.
5. **B — Breathing.** Look, listen and feel for normal breathing for no more than **10 seconds**. Occasional gasps are NOT normal breathing.
6. **C — CPR.** If they are unresponsive and not breathing normally, start CPR — **30 chest compressions to 2 rescue breaths** at a rate of 100–120 compressions per minute.
7. **D — Defibrillation.** Apply an AED as soon as one is available and follow the voice prompts.

When to use DRSABCD

Use DRSABCD on any person who appears collapsed, unconscious, seriously injured, or whose level of response you cannot quickly establish. It is the same framework whether you are dealing with a cardiac arrest, drowning, electrocution, anaphylaxis, head injury or unknown collapse.

Important reminders

- If at any step the person becomes responsive and is breathing normally, place them in the **recovery position** and monitor until the ambulance arrives.
- Do not interrupt chest compressions for more than 10 seconds at a time.
- If you are alone with an infant or child, give 2 minutes of CPR before leaving to call for help.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.